

CAD FORUM
TWENTY YEARS OF GAMING:
ON THE INFLUENCE OF ALFRED C. SNIDER

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It was the end of the 1987 Spring Semester and my first of three years as a debater at Southern Illinois University. Jeff Bile, my coach and the person who taught me more than anyone else ever had (or has) about argumentation, suggested that my growth as a debater would soon come to an end unless I learned the body of theory that existed for academic debate. And so I dutifully trotted off to the library in those pre-Internet days and spent many hours with *CEDA Yearbook* and the *Journal of the American Forensic Association*. I read the work of Rowland and Pfau, Keeshan and Ulrich, Frank and Hunt, Biggers and Berube. But no essay captured my imagination as much as an article written by Alfred Snider on gaming. I was searching for a way to describe and make sense of my own experience as a debater, and the game metaphor did so in a way that no other has before or since that day in the stacks of SIU's Morris Library. To this day, my own published work on debate continues to rely heavily on this turning point in my intellectual development, and a quick review of the debate literature of the last 20 years suggests that my own reliance on Snider's work is hardly unusual.

In this forum, we consider the influence of Snider's germinal 1984 essay on gaming and academic debate. This influence is not uniformly celebrated, as David Frank's essay clearly demonstrates. Nor do the consequences of the gaming perspective entirely satisfy all members of the debate community, as suggested in various ways by the essays of Maxwell Schnurer, Ede Warner, Jr., and Steve Woods. While this forum will not answer definitively even such basic questions as the standing of gaming as a paradigm, it does illustrate the extent of gaming's influence on debate practice and the roles played by Snider's work in shaping the development of academic debate as we left the twentieth century and entered the twenty-first.

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